

exceptional. The OnePlus Nord CE3 features the Qualcomm Snapdragon 782G chipset (which is a slightly improved Snapdragon 778G+ SoC). My review unit came packing 12 GB LPDDR4X RAM and 256 GB UFS 3.1 internal storage, with an option to expand it via microSD card. There's also the RAM Expansion feature that sets aside a predetermined portion of your internal storage as Virtual RAM, allowing for slightly better multitasking abilities.

In benchmarks, the OnePlus Nord CE3 performed admirably well, but it never astounded us as some of the latest mid-rangers did. We're talking about the likes of the iQOO Neo 7 and the POCO F5 which only cost a few thousand bucks more, but offer performance that's truly a class apart. The OnePlus Nord CE3, on the other hand, offers reliable performance across the board. In AnTuTu, the phone scored 6,50,000+ but it was soundly beaten by the iQOO Neo 7 and POCO F5. In GeekBench, we saw the POCO F5 beat the OnePlus Nord CE3 in both Single Core and Multi-Core tests. The performance was comparable to that of the Realme 11 Pro+ and Samsung Galaxy F54.

In GPU benchmarks, The Moto Edge 40 and iQOO Neo 7 blow past the OnePlus Nord CE3 while the Realme 11 Pro+ and Samsung Galaxy F54 perform about the same. So, benchmarks put the OnePlus Nord CE3 around the middle of the pack in the sub-₹30K range. Real-world performance tells the same story. The phone is smooth and fluid when performing basic tasks such as texting, calling, social media, web browsing, and more. Gaming is mostly lag-free, but the phone did heat up after about 20 minutes of playing Call of Duty: Mobile and I faced a couple of frame drops.

We also ran the CPU Throttling Test to see how the phone performs under sustained workloads and the OnePlus Nord CE3 throttled to 77 per cent of its peak performance in 15 minutes. Not the best result, once again.

Overall, the performance of the OnePlus Nord CE3 5G will never leave you disappointed, but it is not a perfor-

mance monster like some of the recent mid-rangers have proved to be. If you're looking for a fluid phone under ₹30K, this is a good choice. However, for pure, unadulterated performance for gaming or other intensive tasks, maybe look at the POCO F5 or iQOO Neo 7 instead.

Moving on to software, the OnePlus Nord CE3 runs Oxygen OS 13.1 on top of Android 13. OnePlus promises 2 years of OS updates and 3 years of security updates, which yet again, lies in the middle of the pack – not the best in business, but decent. OxygenOS 13.1 is feature-rich and highly customisable, there's a lot of character and it is veering closer towards ColorOS than ever before, but it is pleasant to use. Surprisingly though, there's not a lot of bloatware and barely any ads at all.

CAMERAS

The OnePlus Nord CE3 houses a triple camera setup consisting of the popular Sony IMX890 50 MP primary camera, an 8 MP ultrawide shooter, and a 2 MP macro lens. The main camera provides excellent pictures in ideal lighting with good dynamic range and detail. There's a bit of extra contrast added at times and skin tones are not the most accurate, but most photos look pleasing to the eye.

Portrait shots look good as well with decent edge detection and good colour. Human skin tones could be tuned a bit better though. The 8 MP ultrawide shooter is mediocre – it takes a serious hit when it comes to detail and dynamic range. The 2 MP macro lens is decent and clicks some usable shots.

Low light imagery is impressive from the OnePlus Nord CE3's primary camera. Noise and grain are kept to a minimum and the detail and colour are quite stunning for a sub-₹30K phone. There's also a 16 MP selfie camera that clicks vivid and detailed shots in ideal lighting; you get nice-looking portrait shots as well but low light performance isn't great.

BATTERY LIFE

Sporting a large 5,000 mAh battery, the OnePlus Nord CE3 5G has long-lasting

battery life. Coupled with the power-efficient Snapdragon 782G chipset, the phone has more than enough juice to last most users one whole day without a hitch. My day consisted of benchmarking, clicking pictures, shooting 4K videos, watching OTT content, and using Google Maps, and the phone still managed to preserve 21 per cent of its battery capacity by 10 PM that day.

In our video loop test, the OnePlus Nord CE3 lasted a whopping 16 hours from 100-0 per cent, which is fantastic. Moreover, the 80 W SUPERVOOC charging tops up the smartphone from empty to full in just 32 minutes! There's no wireless charging support though.

VERDICT

After spending a week with the OnePlus Nord CE3 5G, I can confidently say that the phone is a well-rounded mid-ranger that ticks many boxes. It has excellent battery life, super fast charging, good performance, an impressive primary camera, and an immersive display. However, the OnePlus Nord CE3 5G never once completely floored me with its performance. Neither does it match up to the performance champs of the mid-range segment nor does it impress with its build and design. It hovers in the middle, providing a safe and reliable option for the masses. I'd suggest you consider the Moto Edge 40 if you're looking for far superior build quality though. And for faster performance, the iQOO Neo 7 is a no-brainer in the sub-₹30,000 price segment.

–Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Qualcomm Snapdragon 782G | GPU: Adreno 642L | RAM: 8/12 GB LPDDR4X | ROM: 128/256 GB UFS 3.1 | OS: OxygenOS 13.1 based on Android 13 | Display: 6.7-inch Fluid AMOLED FHD+, 10-bit Colour, HDR10+ | Display refresh rate: 120 Hz | Battery capacity: 5,000 mAh | Charging: 80 W SUPERVOOC | Cameras (rear): 50 MP Sony IMX890 (OIS) + 8 MP + 2 MP | Camera (selfie): 16 MP (EIS) | Speakers: Dual Stereo Speakers (Dolby Atmos) | Weight: 184 g

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